a scenario where Alice, a finance employee using a managed device with current MFA, attempted to view an internal financial report across several reporting tools. With foundational and shared operational policies in place, each system returned the same decision: access permitted. When Alice repeated the request from an unmanaged device, all systems denied access for the same reason—the foundational device-posture policy—rather than for application-specific quirks.

Over time, Sam's team tracked the percentage of tested scenarios that yielded identical authorization outcomes across participating systems. An increase in consistent decisions indicated that ACME's zero-trust architecture was becoming cohesive: policies were assessed uniformly, signals were interpreted consistently, and trust decisions no longer depended on which system received the request. Decision consistency became a practical sign that Zero Trust was functioning as a shared architectural reality.

15.5.4 Reduced perimeter reliance

Reducing reliance on network-based trust signals was another key indicator of ACME's progress toward Zero Trust. Historically, many systems made implicit assumptions based on network location, VPN membership, or IP address ranges. Requests coming from "inside" the network were often trusted by default, while those from elsewhere were blocked or needed special handling. These perimeter-based shortcuts made access decisions brittle and inconsistent.

ACME measured reduced reliance on perimeter security by tracking how often access decisions depended on network-derived signals versus identity- and context-based signals. The security team inventoried firewall rules, VPN exceptions, and IP allowlists that were still necessary for application access and monitored if these controls were shrinking over time. A decline in new network exceptions—and the retirement of existing ones—indicated that systems relied more on policy-based authorization rather than location.

For example, ACME identified two internal reporting tools that still required users to be on a corporate VPN to access sensitive dashboards, even though the same identity and device-posture checks were already enforced